What does ‘awareness’ mean?

The English term ‘awareness’ can be translated as consciousness. In German-speaking countries, the term refers to an **attitude and practice that counteracts discrimination and (sexualised) violence and promotes consensus-based action.**

Events can create a space for identity formation, encounters and knowledge exchange. These spaces can serve to help people get to know each other and develop a sense of community. However, expectations and personal experiences of events can vary widely. Where some people experience a productive conference, others may experience exclusion, verbal, structural or physical violence.

Discrimination manifests itself in direct interpersonal behaviour and/or through structurally entrenched unequal treatment. **Not all discrimination is conscious or intentional. No space is inherently free of discrimination and violence**.

Examples: Going to the toilet can become a problem if there is only a division between “men” and “women”, but people cannot or do not want to assign themselves to either category. Experiences of violence in public toilets are a reality, especially for trans* and intersex people. Or a single parent may decide not to attend a lecture in order to take on a better-paid night shift, or may not attend because no childcare is available.

Often, such experiences are **not addressed or are addressed inadequately**. Event organisers and visitors may feel that it is unnecessary to have to deal with discrimination and violence. The fear of not being taken seriously can also play a major role. For many, it is unclear who is responsible for such issues and how the problem should be dealt with. In addition, those affected are usually burdened with **feelings of guilt and shame**, which makes it much more difficult to come to terms with what has happened. The myth of the complicity of those affected persists. Their credibility is therefore linked to whether their behaviour before and after the incident, as well as their general lifestyle, correspond to society's image of a “victim”. Victims are asked what they were wearing at the time of

the offence, whether they had consumed substances, or why they did not take immediate action. It is claimed that they should have protected themselves better or reacted differently. Ideas for behavioural change are rarely directed at perpetrators of violence. While it is considered a mitigating factor if they were not sober at the time of the offence, it is often interpreted in the opposite way for victims.

Facets of discrimination

Our society is strongly influenced by power dynamics, meaning that devaluation based on (attributed) characteristics is not uncommon for many people. It may be obvious that discrimination occurs because of (supposed) group affiliation. However, it can also take place unconsciously or covertly and not be recognised as discrimination. Discrimination has many faces. Assaults take the form of verbal, physical, sexualised and psychological violence, such as mean comments, insults, harassment and threats. Sometimes it is barely noticeable to outsiders. It can be irritating looks or a vague feeling that certain groups of people are being excluded or have limited access to a place or certain resources.

The **consequences of discrimination** are immediately apparent. Those affected react to situations very differently, both internally and externally. Often, a feeling of powerlessness and helplessness remains. People may feel excluded or isolated. This can lead to anger, aggression, sadness, disappointment or cynicism. Physical or verbal altercations may occur. Existing traumas can be triggered. If the situation and the emotions involved are not addressed, new traumas can arise.

Various forms of oppression such as racism, classism and sexism overlap and must be considered together (intersectionality). For example, a black woman may be affected by discrimination that is directed only at black women, but not at black men or white women.

Awareness-raising efforts seek to educate and promote understanding of different realities of life, to balance power inequalities, to protect those affected and to prevent (re)traumatisation.

Recognising connections & taking action

Social inequalities exist everywhere. That is why all of our thoughts and actions are shaped by discriminatory patterns. Even people who consider themselves open-minded and tolerant may discriminate or commit acts of violence. This can happen unconsciously or due to a lack of information, even if they do not intend to do so. As soon as a person (apparently) conforms to the social norm in one or more respects, they have less to fear from structural disadvantage in this area and often do not perceive it. Some call this privilege.

That is why it is important to learn about different forms of discrimination and understand how they work. This helps us to recognise and change our own behaviour in this regard. To achieve good awareness, we must question our own self-image and unlearn supposed truths about ourselves. Even if a person is not racist, they can still act in a racist manner. Transphobia also occurs in queer or queer-friendly circles. Even if a person is affected by discrimination on the one hand, they can still discriminate themselves on the other. Sometimes we unconsciously contribute to maintaining discriminatory structures.

What is consensus?

Actions are only consensual if you have the express consent of all participants and those affected!

Consensus is...

Voluntary:

Consent is a decision made of one's own free will and without pressure, manipulation or the influence of drugs or alcohol.

Reversible:

Everyone can change their mind about what they want to do at any time and withdraw their consent. will and without pressure, manipulation or the influence of drugs or alcohol.

Informed:

Consent can only be given if the person is aware of all the background information.

Enthusiastic:

You only have to do things that you really want to do. Not things that you think you have to do.

Specific:

Consent applies to a specific situation. If a person says yes to one thing, it does not mean that they also say yes to other things.

Contact persons

If you have any questions about the workshop schedule and organisation, please feel free to approach us. Our staff will be happy to assist you at any time.

You can be sure that your concerns will be listened to and dealt with in a confidential and responsible manner.

If necessary, please contact Clara Manzel (+49 1515 5948618) or Ilinca Graur (+49 173 3102177, ilinca.m.graur@gmail.com) directly. In an emergency, you can also reach the german police (110) or rescue service (112) by telephone

Source and licence

Excerpts from the brochure ‘Awareness – Dealing with Discrimination & (Sexualised) Violence at Events’ (PDF, 2021, licence: CC BY-SA 3.0) by Initiative Awareness e.V. were used for this awareness concept: Passages from the brochure were summarised, slightly adapted linguistically, supplemented with our own sentences and formulations, and inserted into the sections ‘What does “awareness” mean?’, ‘Facets of discrimination’ and ‘Recognising connections & taking action’ of this awareness concept. This awareness concept is licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0 (website).

This Concept is also largely influenced by the work of Franziska Schaper, Melanie Wilde und Anna-Maria Kamin at the University of Bielefed (https://www.uni-bielefeld.de/fakultaeten/psychologie/abteilung/fachschaft/informationen-fur-erstsem/erstsemester-bachelor-hau/Awarenesskonzept_Erstsemesterfahrt.pdf), as well as the PsyFaKo e.V. Awareness Concepts.